

Briefing II: A Country of Many Countries: Understanding France Through Its History

If someone dropped you into Brittany, Normandy, Paris, and Provence without telling you they were all part of the same country, you might reasonably wonder how they belonged together.

The landscapes are different.

The architecture is different.

The food is different.

The history is different.

Even the nature of the light feels different.

And that is one of the great joys of traveling through France.

In many ways, France was never meant to feel like a single place.

And yet, somehow, it became one.

Understanding how that happened is one of the keys to understanding the country we are about to explore.

One of the easiest mistakes an American visitor can make is to think of France as a single, uniform place. We tend to imagine one French culture, one French cuisine, and one French identity.

I certainly shared this point of view when I first started visiting France more than twenty-five years ago.

But the reality is far more interesting.

The story of France is not the story of a nation that spread outward from a single point. It is the story of many peoples, regions, cultures, and traditions gradually being woven together over nearly two thousand years.

As we travel from Brittany and Normandy through Paris and down into Provence, we'll encounter places that once looked in very different directions for their identities, their trade, and even their futures.

What makes France remarkable is not that those differences disappeared.

It is that they survived.

That idea is worth keeping in mind throughout our journey.

Each time we move to a new region, notice what changes.

The food.

The landscape.

The architecture.

The pace of life.

The accents.

The traditions.

By the end of our trip, I think we'll come to appreciate one of France's greatest strengths: it became a unified nation without ever becoming a uniform one.

Before France Was France

Long before anyone called this place France, the land was home to Celtic tribes known as the Gauls.

If that name sounds familiar, it may be because of Julius Caesar.

In the first century BC, Caesar conquered Gaul and brought it into the Roman world. His victories there became one of the foundations of his rise to power in Rome. But for France, the lasting legacy was not Caesar himself—it was Rome.

The Romans didn't simply occupy the region—they transformed it. They built roads that connected distant communities, founded cities, constructed aqueducts and amphitheaters, introduced Roman law, and tied what is now France into an empire stretching from Britain to North Africa and the Middle East.

Even today, traces of Rome remain everywhere.

Some modern highways still follow Roman routes. Many French towns began as Roman settlements. And when we reach Provence later in our journey, we'll see some of the finest Roman ruins anywhere outside Italy—a reminder that southern France was once one of Rome's most important provinces.

I still remember visiting Arles with Kate and her family in 2007. I was genuinely surprised to find a remarkably well-preserved Roman amphitheater still standing in the middle of the city. It was my first real appreciation for just how deeply Rome still shapes southern France, and I think you'll have a similar reaction when we see these places for ourselves.

When the Roman Empire gradually weakened, new peoples arrived from the north and east.

Among them were the Franks, a Germanic people who eventually gave their name to the country itself.

France.

The land of the Franks.

But don't picture a unified nation emerging overnight.

For centuries, the kings of France often exercised less authority than we imagine today. Powerful nobles ruled their own territories. Great cities looked after their own interests. Local customs, dialects, and loyalties mattered far more to most people than the idea of belonging to a single country.

The France we know today would emerge only gradually.

And that is exactly the story we'll follow as we travel from one region to the next.

Brittany: France's Western Frontier

Our journey begins in Brittany.

That feels entirely appropriate.

If this briefing is about understanding that France is really a collection of distinct regions, Brittany is one of the best places to begin.

Even today, Brittany feels slightly different from the rest of France. Its roots are deeply Celtic. For centuries, its people looked as much toward the Atlantic as they did toward Paris. Its traditions, music, and even its language developed along a somewhat separate path.

That distinct identity remains visible today.

Road signs often appear in both French and Breton.

Local festivals celebrate traditions that long predate the modern French nation.

Seafood, crêpes, and cider remain staples of the regional cuisine.

It is a place that has proudly remained itself while also becoming unmistakably French.

For our family, Brittany also carries a more personal meaning as the place Kate called home more than thirty years ago as an exchange student.

That experience shaped her in ways that still influence our family today.

It is fitting that our own journey begins there.

Our first evening in France won't be spent in a hotel or checking famous landmarks off a list.

It will be spent around the dinner table with the Ferradini family, experiencing Brittany as guests rather than tourists.

I can't imagine a better introduction to France.

Normandy: Where Outsiders Became French

The following day, we cross into Normandy.

Its very name tells a story.

Normandy literally means "Land of the Northmen."

The Northmen were the Vikings.

Beginning in the ninth century, Viking raiders sailed from Scandinavia into what is now France. Their longships entered the great rivers of Europe and traveled astonishing distances inland. The Seine became one of their highways, carrying them all the way to Paris.

Try to picture that for a moment.

Imagine standing on the banks of the Seine and watching Viking longships appear around a bend in the river.

It's one of those moments in history that seems almost impossible to imagine today.

The Vikings attacked towns throughout northern France.

They attacked Paris itself.

Eventually, French rulers made a remarkable decision.

Instead of fighting endless wars, they granted land to Viking leaders in exchange for loyalty and protection.

The newcomers settled.

They married into the local population.

They adopted Christianity.

They learned French.

And over time, they became something entirely new.

They became Normans.

I love this story because it perfectly captures the larger story of France.

People who once arrived as outsiders eventually became part of the nation they had once attacked.

That pattern repeats itself throughout French history.

One of those Normans would become one of the most influential figures in European history.

William the Conqueror.

In 1066, he crossed the English Channel and conquered England, forever changing the English language, monarchy, and legal system.

The story of Normandy didn't stop there.

Nearly nine centuries later, history returned to these same shores.

On June 6, 1944, Allied forces landed on the beaches of Normandy in the largest amphibious invasion ever attempted. Thousands of American, British, Canadian, and Allied soldiers crossed the English Channel to begin the liberation of Western Europe from Nazi occupation.

When we stand at Omaha Beach and later walk through the American Cemetery overlooking the English Channel, we'll be standing in one of the most significant and sacred places of the twentieth century.

When Kate and I visited during our 2008 trip, I was genuinely overwhelmed by the power of the place. It is difficult to describe until you're standing there yourself.

For France, Normandy represents liberation.

For Americans, it represents sacrifice.

For both nations, it represents friendship forged under extraordinary circumstances.

For our own family, that visit may carry an additional meaning.

The Breslers live in Charlestown on the battleground of Bunker Hill, a stark reminder of America's own fight for independence. The Tusseys have their own tradition of service through Clayton's combat deployments with the Marine Corps and Natalie's service as a Naval officer and physician.

The generations and the conflicts are different.

But the values—service, sacrifice, courage, and duty—are timeless.

I have a feeling this will be one of the most meaningful days of our journey.

Paris: The City That Became France

If Brittany reminds us that France is a collection of distinct regions, Paris explains how those regions gradually became a nation.

Its location helps explain why.

The Seine River connected Paris to the English Channel while also reaching deep into the interior of France. Merchants traveled its waters. Ideas spread along its banks. Wealth accumulated there. Over time, French kings increasingly chose Paris as the center of government.

But rivers carry invaders as well as merchants.

As I mentioned earlier, the Vikings who eventually settled Normandy first reached Paris by sailing up the Seine.

One of the most remarkable moments in French history came in 885, when hundreds of Viking longships surrounded the city during the Siege of Paris.

While terrifying for Parisians at the time, that siege revealed something important.

Paris had become too important to ignore.

Over the centuries that followed, French kings steadily expanded their authority from Paris. Roads radiated outward. Laws became more uniform. Trade flourished. Universities attracted scholars from across Europe. Artists, architects, writers, and philosophers gathered here, gradually transforming Paris into not only the political capital of France, but one of the intellectual capitals of the Western world.

Then came revolution.

In 1789, many of the same Enlightenment ideas that had helped inspire the American Revolution exploded in the streets of Paris.

The two revolutions shared many ideals—liberty, representative government, and the belief that ordinary people possessed fundamental rights.

Their paths, however, could hardly have been more different.

The American Revolution largely preserved existing institutions while creating a new nation.

The French Revolution sought to remake society itself.

The years that followed brought extraordinary hope, extraordinary violence, and enormous uncertainty.

Kings fell.

Governments rose and collapsed.

Eventually, a brilliant young military officer named Napoleon Bonaparte emerged from the chaos.

Napoleon is often remembered as one of history's great generals, but for our story his lasting importance lies elsewhere.

He helped complete the transformation of France from a patchwork of regional identities into a far more unified nation. His government standardized laws, strengthened national institutions, and reinforced the idea that people from Brittany, Normandy, Paris, Provence, and everywhere in between belonged to the same country.

Modern France still bears his imprint.

Modern Paris also owes much of its appearance to the nineteenth century.

By the mid-1800s, the city was still a maze of narrow medieval streets. During the reign of Napoleon III, his prefect, Baron Georges-Eugène Haussmann, undertook one of the most ambitious urban redesigns in history.

Entire neighborhoods were transformed.

Broad boulevards replaced winding streets.

Elegant stone apartment buildings lined new avenues.

Gas streetlights illuminated the city after dark.

An extensive modern sewer system dramatically improved public health.

Parks and public squares were created.

Grand public buildings, including the magnificent Palais Garnier opera house, helped give Paris much of the appearance we recognize today.

The transformation was so influential that cities around the world began borrowing its ideas.

In the United States, planners looked to Paris as they redesigned their own growing cities. Frederick Law Olmsted's park systems, Daniel Burnham's Plan of Chicago, and the grand civic avenues of Washington, D.C. all reflect, in different ways, the idea that a modern city should be not only functional, but beautiful, orderly, and public.

So when we walk down the Boulevard Saint-Germain, Avenue de l'Opéra, or the Champs-Élysées, we are not simply admiring beautiful streets.

We are seeing one of history's most influential examples of urban planning.

That is one of the great pleasures of Paris.

Almost every street reveals layers of history.

A Roman foundation.

A medieval cathedral.

A royal palace.

A revolutionary square.

A nineteenth-century boulevard.

A twentieth-century memorial.

A vibrant twenty-first-century city.

Few places allow you to experience so many centuries in a single afternoon.

When we arrive in Paris, we'll spend five days exploring museums, churches, neighborhoods, cafés, and monuments that span nearly two thousand years of history.

For Kate, Paris is more than another stop on our itinerary. During her junior year of college, she spent a semester living and studying here, getting to know the city not simply through its famous landmarks, but through everyday life. Together, Rennes and Paris gave her the opportunity to experience France from two very different perspectives—one through the rhythm of provincial life, the other through one of the world's great capital cities.

There will be plenty of opportunities in a later briefing to talk about the Eiffel Tower, Notre-Dame, the Louvre, Montmartre, and everything else that makes Paris one of the world's great cities.

For now, I simply hope you'll see Paris as something more than a beautiful destination.

It is the city that gradually gathered many Frances together and helped shape them into one.

And in just a few weeks, we'll have the privilege of walking through that history ourselves.

Provence: Where France Turns Toward the Sun

Our final destination will feel like we've arrived in an entirely different country.

We'll leave behind the broad beaches of Normandy, the grand boulevards of Paris, and the cooler skies of northern France.

Instead, we'll enter a landscape of vineyards, olive groves, cypress trees, and fields of lavender stretching toward distant hills.

This is Provence.

If Paris is often described as the heart of France, Provence might just be its soul.

For thousands of years, people have been drawn to this corner of the Mediterranean.

The Greeks established trading settlements here more than 2,500 years ago.

The Romans transformed the region, building roads, aqueducts, amphitheaters, and entire cities whose remarkably well-preserved remains still shape the landscape today. As we explore Provence, we'll find reminders of the Roman Empire almost everywhere we go.

Centuries later, Provence found itself at the center of another remarkable chapter of history. For nearly seventy years during the 1300s, the Popes ruled the Catholic Church not from Rome, but from nearby Avignon. Their magnificent palace still dominates the city today, a reminder that for a brief period, this corner of southern France became the center of the Christian world.

The Popes even left their mark on one of the region's most famous wines. Just north of Avignon lies the village of Châteauneuf-du-Pape—literally "the Pope's New Castle." The vineyards planted to supply the papal court eventually became one of France's most celebrated wine regions, and today its name remains a reminder of that remarkable chapter in history.

Even after Provence became part of France, it never lost its distinctly Mediterranean character. Its architecture, cuisine, climate, and relaxed way of life still feel noticeably different from northern France.

Yet what most visitors remember isn't simply its history.

It's the feeling of the place.

The brilliant Mediterranean light.

The scent of lavender and rosemary carried on a warm breeze.

The rhythm of village markets.

Long lunches beneath the shade of plane trees.

A glass of local rosé enjoyed as the sun begins to set.

It isn't difficult to understand why artists like Cézanne and Van Gogh found endless inspiration here.

The landscape itself seems to invite people to slow down, notice more, and appreciate simple pleasures.

That's exactly how we'll end our own journey.

After days filled with cathedrals, museums, castles, battlefields, and centuries of history, we'll have time simply to enjoy being together.

We'll explore villages.

We'll visit markets.

We'll spend afternoons by the pool.

We'll share meals that stretch long into the evening.

And perhaps most importantly, we'll leave ourselves enough unstructured time for the unexpected discoveries that often become the memories we treasure most.

There's something fitting about ending our adventure here.

Not by rushing to one last landmark, but by embracing the slower pace of southern France and enjoying the company of the people we've shared the journey with.

France and America: Cousins in Revolution

As we conclude this briefing, I wanted to touch on one more topic.

For Americans, one part of French history may feel surprisingly familiar.

The American Revolution and the French Revolution were born from many of the same ideas.

The connection begins with a young French aristocrat named the Marquis de Lafayette.

Still a teenager, Lafayette crossed the Atlantic to support the American cause. He became one of George Washington's most trusted generals and one of the great heroes of the Revolution.

Many of the younger members of our expedition already know him from *Hamilton*.

History turns out to be every bit as interesting as the musical.

French money, French weapons, French soldiers, and French naval power played a crucial role in securing American independence.

Without French support, the American story might have unfolded very differently.

Yet when revolution came to France, the outcome was not the same.

The United States emerged with a stable constitutional system.

France experienced years of upheaval, violence, dictatorship, empire, monarchy, republic, and then monarchy again before eventually finding lasting stability.

The comparison is fascinating.

Two nations inspired by similar ideas arrived at very different destinations.

One produced George Washington.

The other produced Napoleon.

Both stories continue to shape the modern world.

But as we discussed earlier, the special relationship between France and America did not end with revolution.

Nearly two centuries later, their histories of course intersected again on the beaches of Normandy.

As we stand at Omaha Beach and walk through the American Cemetery, we will be visiting places where French and American history once again collided.

History is never exactly the same.

But it often rhymes.

Standing among the white crosses overlooking the English Channel, history may feel a little less distant than it otherwise would.